

Tying up syntactic loose ends: *hwæt/huat*-clauses in Old English and Old Saxon

George Walkden • gw249@cam.ac.uk • <http://www.srcf.ucam.org/~gw249/>

Department of Linguistics, University of Cambridge

The problem

- Minority syntactic patterns that resist generalization
 - ungrammatical?
 - competing grammar?
 - or do we just need to look harder?

Outline of the talk

1. The traditional view of *hwæt/huat*
2. Problems with the traditional view
3. Constituent order in *hwæt/huat*-clauses
4. Synchronic analysis of *hwæt/huat*-clauses
5. Some diachronic suggestions
6. Conclusion and implications

The first line of Beowulf

Hwæt we Gardena	in geardagum •
HWÆT we Spear-Danes.GEN	in year-days.DAT

peodcyninga	brym gefrunon
people-kings.GEN	power know.1PL

hu ða æþelingas	ellen fremedon •
how then princes.NOM	deeds performed

‘We truly know about the might of the nation-kings in the ancient times of the Spear-Danes how princes then performed deeds of valour’
(Beowulf, ll. 1–3; Bammesberger 2006: 3)

Translations of *hwæt*

'Attend!' 'Yes' 'Yo.' 'Hear me!'
'What ho!'
'Behold!' 'So.'
'Lo!'



Hwæt as an interjection

- Grimm (1837: 450):
 - Specific to OE and OS
 - Not interrogative
 - Can't be an artefact of Latin
 - Always clause-initial
 - Often introduces speech
- 'ein bloßer ausruf, jedoch in sehr gemäßigtem sinn'
(*'a pure interjection, albeit in a very restrained sense'*)

2. Problems with the traditional view

- *Hwæt* doesn't always initiate speech
 - in fact, it's found in very non-oral texts
- Stanley (2000):
 - *hwæt* is usually metrically unstressed (2000: 556)
 - *hwæt* is never followed by punctuation in the manuscripts (2000: 525)
 - Ælfric's grammar of Latin and OE did not include *hwæt* as an interjection (2000: 541)

3. Constituent order in *hwæt/huat*-clauses

- Old English displays a clear asymmetry between declarative root and subordinate clauses (cf. Pintzuk 1999)
- So does Old Saxon (Erickson 1997; Walkden 2010)
- Difference between verb position in OS root and subordinate clauses:

	V 1/V 2		V-later		Total
	N	%	N	%	N
Root	875	94.0	56	6.0	931
Subordinate	182	21.2	677	78.8	859
Total	1057	—	733	—	1790

Huat-clauses vs. root clauses

- Difference between verb position in OS root clauses and *huat*-clauses is statistically significant (Fisher's exact test; $p < 0.0001$)

	V1/V2		V-later		Total
	N	%	N	%	N
<i>Huat</i>	9	36.0	16	64.0	25
Non- <i>huat</i>	875	94.0	56	6.0	931
Total	884	—	72	—	956

Huat-clauses vs. subordinate clauses

- Difference between verb position in OS subordinate clauses and *huat*-clauses is **not** statistically significant (Fisher's exact test; $p=0.0856$)

	V1/V2		V-later		Total
	N	%	N	%	N
<i>Huat</i>	9	36.0	16	64.0	25
Non- <i>huat</i>	182	21.2	677	78.8	859
Total	191	—	693	—	884

And in Old English...

- Situation is the same for the OE translation of Bede's *Historia* (root vs *hwæt*-clauses: $p < 0.0001$; subordinate vs. *hwæt*-clauses: $p = 0.5657$, n.s.)

	V 1 / V 2		V-later		Total
	N	%	N	%	N
Root (non- <i>hwæt</i>)	1 8 9 8	6 9 . 9	8 1 9	3 0 . 1	2 7 1 7
Subordinate	1 8 6 3	3 7 . 8	3 0 6 7	6 2 . 2	4 9 3 0
<i>Hwæt</i>	9	3 1 . 0	2 0	6 9 . 0	2 9
Total	3 7 7 0	—	3 9 0 6	—	7 6 7 6

4. Synchronic analysis

- Munaro & Obenauer (1999):
 - Ranges of meanings for interrogative pronouns in German, French and Pagotto intersect in several key ways
 - can mean ‘why’ or ‘how’ in questions
 - can occur non-argumentally in exclamatives
 - Hypothesis: interrogative pronouns are **underspecified** in these languages

Hwæt-clauses as exclamatives

- Rett's (2008) Degree Restriction:
 - An exclamative can only be used to express surprise that the degree property which is its content holds of a particular degree.
 - 'exclamatives pattern in their morphosyntax with free relatives rather than with questions' (Rett 2008: 173)
 - Holds perfectly in OE and OS if we assume that *hwæt*-clauses are exclamatives

Beowulf revisited

Hwæt we Gardena	in geardagum •
HWÆT we Spear-Danes.GEN	in year-days.DAT

þeodcyninga	þrym gefrunon
people-kings.GEN	power know.1PL

hu ða æþelingas	ellen fremedon •
how then princes.NOM	deeds performed

Suggestion, following the exclamative hypothesis:

- ‘How much we have heard of the might of the nation-kings of the Spear-Danes!’

Advantages of the exclamative hypothesis

- Accounts for the constituent order facts
- Does not need to maintain that *hwæt* is an interjection
- Brings the behaviour of *hwæt* into line with that of a range of other interrogative pronouns observed cross-linguistically

5. Diachronic suggestions

- Change toward underspecification seems ‘natural’
- OE, OS and Old Norse display underspecification (not Gothic or OHG)
 - diffusion across Northwest Germanic dialect continuum?
- Reanalysis of **hwat* as left-peripheral, in examples where it occurs extracted from a complex nominal
- Once **hwat* had become detached from its position in the paradigm of argumental interrogative pronouns and was able to be interpreted as underspecified ‘how’, it could then be extended unproblematically to exclamatives

6. Conclusions

- The traditional view of *hwæt/huat* is unsatisfactory:
 - *hwæt/huat* must usually be analysed as unstressed
 - no punctuation between *hwæt/huat* and the following clause is ever found
 - a contemporary grammarian did not analyse *hwæt/huat* as an interjection
 - *hwæt/huat* does not exclusively serve to initiate speech
 - clauses preceded by *hwæt/huat* pattern with subordinate clauses, not with main clauses, with respect to the position of the verb.

More conclusions

- According to the alternative analysis pursued in sections 4 and 5:
 - *hwæt/huat* in OE and OS was underspecified for the feature [thing]
 - non-interrogative clauses preceded by *hwæt/huat* are wh-exclamatives similar in interpretation to Modern English ‘How tall you’ve grown!’
 - The underspecification of *hwæt/huat* may have originated in Proto-Ingvaeonic through reanalysis of interrogatives containing *hwæt/huat* extracted from a complex nominal constituent.

Implications

- Ontologically, grammar competition definitely appears to exist (bilingualism and bidialectalism exist); see Kroch 1989.
- But methodologically, in certain cases, positing competing grammars in free variation may obscure systematic (interpretively significant) variation and fine-grained distinctions.
- The hypothesis of free variation should therefore be a last resort.
- In other words, it's worth continuing to look for regularities within apparently recalcitrant syntactic data, rather than assuming ungrammaticality or free variation.

Thank you for listening!